The phrase ‘Looking East’ certainly connotes a vector but has evolved into a diplomatic metaphor. Initially, it started out as an expression of India’s opening out to the world after decades of relatively autarchic growth. Because our early partnerships in the 1990s were with members of the ASEAN, it then acquired a specific meaning as developing ties with them. In due course, efforts were made to establish more connectivity with that region – physical, virtual as well as its softer incarnations. Engagement with ASEAN was also reflected in India’s participation in various ASEAN-centric forums. An agenda of trade, investment and economic changes thus grew steadily into something much larger. It also then went beyond ASEAN to cover Japan, the Republic of Korea and China. With the first two, India concluded free trade agreements, while with China, trade volumes expanded dramatically. In recent years, this outreach has extended to Australia and the Pacific Islands. As a result, India’s foreign policy acquired a footprint and dimension that it did not have earlier. The profundity of this change is underlined by the larger mind space that the world to India’s East now occupies when it comes to economics, technology, security, strategy or even culture.

While the relevance of the East to India’s global positioning has been steadily increasing, it escalates sharply when there is a substantial change in the capabilities and influence of its major powers. With China, that has already happened and is beginning to be felt. With Japan, that is a prospect which is still only unfolding.

Since 1945, that country has largely tailored its security outlook to the requirements of its American alliance. That dynamic also justified Japan’s assistance and investments in China, although commercial considerations and post-war obligations were also key factors. After accounting for a larger proportion of the US trade deficit than China does today, Japan stepped back in the 1980s. It consciously chose to discipline its expectations within the alliance construct. Then, having become the second biggest economy in 1987 overtaking the USSR, it yielded that place to China in 2010.

This has had both psychological and strategic implications. Neighbours are most affected by rising powers and Japan proved no exception to this rule. Its interest in ensuring continental and regional stability is today buttressed